

## Chapter 138-1: Birthday

Chu Qingqiu was rarely flustered. She covered her face and coughed, clutching the white bone as she turned around, smoothing down the disheveled strands of hair at her forehead before pushing Ning Fuyi from behind.

Ning Fuyi staggered back two steps from her push, opening her eyes to look outside the barrier. She saw those people turning red-faced as they scrambled to get up, none daring to look in this direction again.

Only Jiuying felt no embarrassment. She stood with her hands on her hips, laughing until her eyes were mere slits.

"Ning Fuyi, what are you standing there for!" She raised her hand to tap the barrier, shouting at the top of her voice, "Hurry up and open it for this old lady!"

Ning Fuyi glanced at Chu Qingqiu, then raised her hand to dispel the barrier for them. Jiuying walked step by step to the two with her hands behind her back, stretching her nose toward Ning Fuyi's ear. Ning Fuyi startled and immediately swatted her away.

"What?" she asked warily.

Jiuying said nothing, only kept winking at her, squeezing her smooth nose tip into several furrows. After a long while, she finally spoke: "You're covered in flower fragrance—don't try to fool me."

Ning Fuyi licked her lips, waving her hands to bat Jiuying aside, saying in a low voice: "Go away!"

She turned to look at Chu Qingqiu, who stood straight as if she didn't care, but her right hand tightly gripping the white bone betrayed her inner embarrassment.

The arrivals were indeed Jiuying, Jiang Li, Liu Wenzhu, and Qiu Yi.

"Divine Physician Jiang, Wenzhu, would you like to sit?" Ning Fuyi rubbed her palms together, then conjured several more rattan chairs and wooden tables from the flower cluster, gesturing for them to sit.

Jiang Li lowered her eyes and sat down with a smile. Qiu Yi also kept her head down, not daring to look at her master. But clearly the most uncomfortable was Liu Wenzhu—though she had witnessed some things before, it was nothing compared to the embrace she'd just seen.

She kept glancing at Chu Qingqiu from time to time, looking as if she might faint.

But this wasn't surprising either. In her perspective, Chu Qingqiu was an unattainable Divine Venerable<sup>1</sup>, the sect leader of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, a revered elder.

Ning Fuyi had always displayed her dislike for Chu Qingqiu openly before. Now that the two were suddenly so intimate, it would indeed take some time to accept.

Seeing the atmosphere growing tense, Jiuying broke the silence again. She half-reclined in her rattan chair, then picked a wild flower: "How do I remember Purple Cloud Peak being barren, without even a single blade of grass or worm? Coming here today and seeing such scenery, I almost thought I'd flown to the wrong place."

"Love truly can make withered wood bloom again in spring." Jiuying cupped her cheek, her eyes full of intoxication.

"Stop joking around." Ning Fuyi tapped her on the head, then pulled over the uncomfortable Chu Qingqiu to sit together, waving her hand to summon tea water, acting as if this were her own home.

"I heard you had a direct confrontation with the immortal sects and even fought. Were any of you injured?" Jiang Li asked with concern while taking out her medicine box.

"No harm done. With the Divine Venerable here, none of us suffered losses." Ning Fuyi smiled.

"Fortunately, that Hua Feihua<sup>2</sup> still has some sense of righteousness and covered up the matter of my demonic qi. But seeing how Hua Hong acted so hypocritically, I wonder if he'll blame him when they return."

"I happen to have business with the Flying Flower Sect in a few days. If you're worried, you can come with me." Liu Wenzhu suddenly spoke, her tone as gentle as usual, though she didn't dare look toward Chu Qingqiu.

Ning Fuyi nodded: "This matter indeed deserves our thanks."

"Shouldn't you thank me? That day I was rushing around blocking their mouths one by one. Even Tang Wenshu was persuaded by my persistent coaxing to promise to keep your secret. Only that Hua Feiwu was nowhere to be found, then turned around and sold you out. If I'd known, I would have swallowed him in one bite and saved us all this trouble." Jiuying angrily slapped the table.

"Thank you, of course I must thank you." Ning Fuyi blew her a kiss, causing Jiuying to quickly wrap her arms around her own shoulders and glare flirtatiously at her.

Ning Fuyi's gaze shifted to Jiang Li, who had been smiling the whole time. After hesitating for a moment, she asked: "Divine Physician Jiang, are you... all right?"

The smile on Jiang Li's face paused slightly, but she soon beamed again: "My injuries have healed, so naturally I'm fine."

"Though she captured me, aside from the initial confrontation, she never really harmed me. Plus, I knew her past like the back of my hand, so I quickly guessed the whole story."

She paused, then continued: "Seeing you two like this makes me very happy. As for other matters, perhaps it's destiny. I've done what I should do, so I won't force anything."

Ning Fuyi saw the sorrow that always flowed in her eyes and knew she wasn't as carefree as her words suggested, but didn't know how to comfort her. She could only fill her teacup with tea.

"Afterward, there was no more news of Black Scales?" Ning Fuyi asked.

Jiang Li shook her head.

Seeing the atmosphere turn somber again, Jiuying clapped her hands: "All right, after you and the Divine Venerable caused that commotion at Flying Flower Tower yesterday, the matter of Penglai<sup>3</sup> secretly refining Infinite Ghost Fire spread throughout all the immortal sects. Now all sects no longer trust Penglai easily and guard against them deeply. I suspect Penglai already knows."

"Fuyi, you and the Divine Venerable should be careful these days. I feel Penglai might not let you go." Liu Wenzhu said worriedly. "To dare refine something like Infinite Ghost Fire—when I mention Penglai now, I always feel they've gone mad."

Ning Fuyi hummed in agreement, looking toward the silent Chu Qingqiu.

After clearly receiving Chu Qingqiu's love, she suddenly became timid and hesitant. Yesterday she had even thought of no longer interfering in Penglai's affairs, abandoning her pursuit of justice against Penglai, and living in seclusion.

That's why she had said those words to Chu Qingqiu—she didn't want even the slightest possibility of being separated from Chu Qingqiu again.

After all, now both of them no longer had the possibility of starting over.

She reached into Chu Qingqiu's palm, feeling the other's responsive grip. Chu Qingqiu seemed to understand her thoughts. Without saying anything, she just raised her hand to tuck a strand of her hair behind her ear.

The intimate gesture made the others look up at the sky again.

"All right, we should talk about something cheerful today." Jiuying stretched like a cat and yawned. "Tonight there's a temple fair in Star Point Town. Why don't we join in the fun and set up a feast on this mountain to celebrate everyone's safety?"

"Star Point Town temple fair? On Purple Cloud Peak, ten thousand zhang<sup>4</sup> above ground, I'm afraid we won't even see a single sky lantern." Ning Fuyi spoke as if hearing a fairy tale.

"What does it matter? We're just borrowing some festive spirit—it's not like you need to move the whole town up here." Jiuying stretched her arms to nudge Chu Qingqiu, winking at her. "Divine Venerable, you decide."

Chu Qingqiu glanced at her, initially wanting to refuse, but seeing her eyebrow gestures for a moment, she understood something.

"I think livening things up wouldn't be bad at all," she said.

"Divine Venerable, has the sun risen from the west? You actually enjoy festivities?" Ning Fuyi found it hard to believe, but since Chu Qingqiu had spoken, she had no reason to object and could only agree.

## Chapter 138-2: Birthday

After midday, Ning Fuyi was dragged down the mountain by Liu Wenzhu to shop, saying that mortal delicacies and fine foods were needed for a festive atmosphere. The two nearly toured the entire Star Point Town, filling the Memory Bead<sup>5</sup> with wine, preserved foods, and other delights.

They wandered until dusk fell, with wild geese against the slanting sun and distant mountains appearing and disappearing, before finally heading home.

"Fuyi, word has spread throughout the immortal sects now. Are you really with the Divine Venerable..." Liu Wenzhu asked quietly while easily carrying two wine jars.

Ning Fuyi didn't deflect but nodded in acknowledgment.

"Oh..." Liu Wenzhu nodded, accidentally gripping the wine jar so hard it cracked, then quickly loosened her grip. "Don't misunderstand—I don't mean anything by it, I'm just shocked."

"Since I never told you about this, it's natural you'd be shocked." Ning Fuyi said. "We've been through quite a lot together. It's complicated and hard to explain in detail."

"It's all right." Liu Wenzhu quickly shook her head. "Whatever you do, I won't say a single bad word."

Ning Fuyi looked at her face, which had grown much more serene over the past two years, and smiled gratefully.

"Fuyi, what kind of feeling do you have for the Divine Venerable?" Liu Wenzhu suddenly asked.

"What kind of feeling?" Ning Fuyi walked out of town in the sunlight, looking up thoughtfully. "I haven't really thought about it carefully."

"Perhaps it's that even though the evening glow is brilliant and the clouds are magnificent, none of it compares to the captivating power of her smile." Ning Fuyi answered.

Liu Wenzhu nodded as if she understood, though she didn't quite.

When the two returned to Purple Cloud Peak, the fiery sun had only half its face left, hiding behind the green mountains to bid farewell to the mortal world. Outdoor seating had been set up among the flower clusters, with hundreds of flower lanterns scattered about, their flickering lights like stars fallen to earth.

Ning Fuyi was about to approach for a closer look when Jiang Li, carrying her medicine box, grabbed her arm and forcibly pulled her in a circle, stumbling and dragging her into the stone hall.

"What are you..." Ning Fuyi turned back to look for Chu Qingqiu's figure, but before she could find that graceful silhouette, the stone hall door slammed shut.

"I was so busy with pleasantries earlier that I almost forgot to examine you. I heard you've suffered injury upon injury along this journey. I don't know if there are any remnants in your body, so I should take a look to be safe." Jiang Li moved efficiently, and before she finished speaking, silver threads from her fingertips had already settled on Ning Fuyi's pulse, carefully probing.

Ning Fuyi could only let her be: "Those injuries are long healed."

"Do you know how many people's chronic ailments come about? It's from avoiding treatment. If every cultivator could heal themselves, what would we Divine Physicians be needed for?" Jiang Li continued her careful examination.

After a long while, she finally withdrew the silver threads and took out various bottles and vials from her medicine box, mixing them for quite some time before handing them to Ning Fuyi.

"You see, your immortal meridians are still damaged. Though not serious, you can't be careless. Take two of these pills daily, don't forget."

"Thank you." Ning Fuyi said, lowering her head to smell the bottle—it had no particular scent.

Jiang Li glanced toward the door, then suddenly packed up her medicine box and smiled brightly: "All right, let's go out."

Ning Fuyi didn't know what she was plotting. Confused, she put the bottle away, turned to push open the door, but at the moment of opening it, she straightened her spine and nearly struck down with a thunderbolt.

Two birds, one black and one white, flew before her, screeching: "Congratulations to the Hall Master on your fiftieth birthday! May the Hall Master be as blessed as the Eastern Sea and live as long as the Southern Mountains!"

Not satisfied with just shouting, two gold-trimmed red banners unfurled from their beaks. On the left: "Blessed as the Eastern Sea," on the right: "Live as Long as the Southern Mountains," and another floated down from above reading: "Grand Achievements and Dominance."

Ning Fuyi's shame immediately surpassed her shock. Under Jiang Li's pushing, she forced a smile, restraining her fingertips from burning those red banners to ash.

Han Ya<sup>6</sup> and Xi Que<sup>7</sup> finished their clamoring and chirped as they landed, transforming into human form. Han Ya bounced forward to claim credit, but Ning Fuyi covered her face and sidestepped away from her, fleeing like an escapist.

It must have been those two who came up with such "eloquent" congratulatory words. If she stayed a moment longer, she might accidentally roast them both.

The others stood on both sides, all laughing so hard they couldn't close their mouths. Besides those from earlier, Rong Jin was also among them, and the whole group applauded enthusiastically.

Ning Fuyi grabbed the resplendent Jiuying from the crowd and pulled at her hair: "This was your idea? Qi Jiuying, my birthday is on Qingming<sup>8</sup>, and it's already late spring now. What birthday are you celebrating? And fifty-five years old, you..."

"Let go!" Jiuying's phoenix eyes watered from pain as she rescued her precious hair. "It's not that long past—what's wrong with making it up?"

"Wasn't it because Liu Wenzhu said that since you were born on Qingming, no one ever celebrated your birthday, so I took pity on you." Jiuying tilted her head. "Besides, your Divine Venerable was also one of the masterminds behind this. Why don't you go yell at her instead?"

Ning Fuyi's grip on her loosened. Liu Wenzhu's words were true—because every Qingming brought countless returning ghosts, the sect would be too busy to handle anything else, especially Ning Changfeng. Where would there be time for birthday celebrations?

Thinking about this, her heart softened. Just as she was about to say something, cheers suddenly erupted behind her.

She instinctively looked toward the cheering, and raising her eyes, she saw sparks flying everywhere—fireworks as large as a mountain peak illuminated the entire Purple Cloud Peak.

"A thousand lights on trees, seven branches of flames blooming"<sup>9</sup>—the firelight masked the colors of stars and moon, leaving enduring halos in her eyes.

Her heart raced wildly with each explosion, and she saw a blurred figure stepping out from the blooming starfire, robes falling gracefully like glowing embers.

After Ning Fuyi saw who it was, she could no longer contain her smile. The fireworks stung her eyes, and she ran forward almost at a sprint.

Chu Qingqiu smiled gently. Instead of her usual white robes, she wore a peach-pink dress with two gossamer-thin veils hanging from her arms. Her hair, bound with silk threads, was adorned with flowers, and the bright colors made her appear several degrees more radiant.

She extended her arms toward Ning Fuyi, who threw herself into the embrace and held her tightly.

"How is it? Does it match your immortal power perfectly?" Chu Qingqiu said softly, patting her back with her palm. "Jiuying said you'd like it, so I wore it."

"You believe whatever she says?" Ning Fuyi said in a muffled voice, her heart melting completely. After a long while, she finally let go.

"I have a gift for you." Chu Qingqiu said, her face slightly flushed. She took Ning Fuyi's hand, and suddenly something cool touched her wrist.

Ning Fuyi raised her hand—it was a jade bracelet identical to the one on Chu Qingqiu's wrist, except this one had never been broken, so it lacked the golden leaf wrapping.

"I didn't know what to give you. You seem to lack nothing, so I went to the mortal realm to find an identical bracelet, thinking you might like it." Chu Qingqiu said. "I prepared this long ago, but only now am I giving it to you."

"There's an inscription on it." She poked Ning Fuyi's arm with her finger.

Before Ning Fuyi could savor this gesture, her eyes had already fallen on the bracelet. The jade was emerald green and smooth, but finding such a thing from thirty years ago in the mortal world, where items changed rapidly, would be like searching for an antique—certainly not easy.

Just then another firework bloomed, and by its bright light, Ning Fuyi saw a line of elegant characters. From the brushwork, it appeared Chu Qingqiu had carved it herself without using immortal power.

She read aloud: "I would shoulder three lifetimes of snow to become half a lamp's light for you."<sup>10</sup>

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### Footnotes:

<sup>1</sup> **Divine Venerable (神尊)** - A high-ranking title in the cultivation world, indicating someone of god-like status and power

<sup>2</sup> **Hua Feihua** - A character's name meaning "Flower Non-flower," following Chinese naming conventions where names often have poetic or philosophical meanings

<sup>3</sup> **Penglai (蓬莱)** - In Chinese mythology, Penglai is one of the legendary islands of the immortals. Here it refers to a powerful sect

<sup>4</sup> **Zhang (丈)** - A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.33 meters or 10.9 feet

<sup>5</sup> **Memory Bead (一念珠)** - A magical storage device that can hold vast amounts of items in a small space

<sup>6</sup> **Han Ya (寒鸦)** - Literally "Cold Crow," one of Ning Fuyi's bird companions

<sup>7</sup> **Xi Que (喜鹊)** - Literally "Magpie," one of Ning Fuyi's bird companions

<sup>8</sup> **Qingming (清明)** - The Tomb Sweeping Festival, a traditional Chinese holiday for honoring ancestors, occurring in early April. In cultivation novels, it's often associated with spiritual activity

<sup>9</sup> **"A thousand lights on trees, seven branches of flames blooming"** - A poetic description of fireworks, evoking classical Chinese poetry about festivals and celebrations

<sup>10</sup> **"I would shoulder three lifetimes of snow to become half a lamp's light for you"** - A deeply romantic inscription expressing willingness to endure great hardship (three lifetimes of snow/cold) just to provide warmth and guidance (half a lamp's light) for the beloved. This type of poetic expression is common in Chinese romantic literature.